

Recruiting staff

After July 1862, each Union regiment was required to have a surgeon and two assistant surgeons who were, in turn, overseen by brigade and divisional surgeons. Stretcher-bearers and field hospital orderlies—at first, drawn from regimental and brigade musicians—were ill-trained, but later made up a special branch within the Union medical department. Confederate regiments were supposed to have one surgeon and one assistant surgeon, and followed a similar hierarchy up the chain of command. All their doctors had to pass a special examination administered by a military medical board, except when civilian doctors were recruited after large battles. The United States Colored Troops had a separate medical department that mirrored the overall Union model, but with less stringent requirements for doctors and nurses. Consequently, death rates for wounded or ill Black American soldiers were much higher than for their white counterparts.



Union hospital in Washington, D.C.

Field hospitals were hastily put together and inadequate. As the poet Walt Whitman wrote: "I suppose you know that what we call hospital here in the field, is nothing but a collection of tents, on the bare ground for a floor, rather hard accommodations for a sick man."

Infectious diseases

Disease killed twice as many troops as battlefield injuries. Sometimes entire campaigns were called off because of sickness. In May 1862, Confederate general P. G. T. Beauregard abandoned Corinth, Mississippi, to advancing Federals under General Henry